Uttar Pradesh. And all three candidates were dynasts, including Bhavya Bishnoi, son of Congress defector Kuldeep Bishnoi and grandson of the late CM Bhajan Lal, in Adampur. On September 14, Goa MLA Michael Lobo headed a group of seven Congress MLAs who crossed over to join the BJP, which rules the state. Lobo, in fact, had quit the BJP only in January, after the party refused a ticket to wife Delilah for the February 2022 election. On September 19, it was former Punjab chief minister Captain Amarinder Singh who was weaving his newly formed Punjab Lok Congress (PLC) into the saffron fold. The titular raja of Patiala also brought on board wife Preneet Kaur, the Congress MP from Patiala, son Raninder, daughter Jai Inder and grandson Nirvan Singh. Not exactly a dynasty-free group portrait.

Realpolitik has a way of skewering public postures. Perhaps it goes deeper. For instance, the BJP's love for ex-royals—the very apogee of unreserved entitlement—remains intact. Sundry royals have been part of the scenery since the party's beginnings and, indeed, Gwalior *rajmata* Vijayaraje Scindia was one of the party's founders and also a part of the A.B. Vajpayee government at the turn of the century. Her daughters Vasundhara Raje, the powerful ex-CM of Rajasthan, and Yashodhara Raje Scindia, a minister in the Madhya Pradesh government, have always been in positions of power in the party. Vasundhara's son Dushyant Singh is also the BJP MP from Jhalawar-Baran. Nephew Jyotiraditya, of course, joined the party late but was seated with honour at the banquet, as Union minister.

And this is just the tip of the nepotism iceberg within the BJP edifice. Prime Minister Modi's cabinet has 15 ministers who are either products of dynastic politics or are building their own. About 12 per cent of the BJP's 395 parliamentarians (Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha included) are dynasts. Two chief ministers, Pema Khandu in Arunachal Pradesh and Basavaraj Bommai in Karnataka, are children of former CMs. In Maharashtra, deputy chief minister Devendra Fadnavis's father Gangadharpant Fadnavis was a member of the Maharashtra legislative council.

NDA'S DYNASTIC ALLIES



Shiv Sena (Shinde faction), Maharashtra: Eknath Shinde's son **Shrikant Shinde** is an MP



Lok Janashakti Party (LJP), Bihar: The late Ram Vilas Paswan's son **Chirag** and brother Pashupati run rival factions



Apna Dal (Sonelal), UP The late Sonelal Patel's daughter **Anupriya Patel** leads this faction



National People's Party (NPP), Meghalaya: The late P.A. Sangma's son **Conrad Sangma** runs it



Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK), TN: **S. Ramadoss** and his family head this party of the Vanniyar cohort



Tamil Maanila Congress (TMC), TN: Led by **G.K. Vasan**, son of founder G.K. Moopanar



Shiromani Akali Dal (Democratic), Punjab **Sukhdev Dhindsa** and his family control the party



Punjab Lok Congress (PLC), Punjab: **Amarinder Singh's** party has merged with BJP



Jannayak Janta Party (JJP), Haryana: **Dushyant Chautala** is a fourth gen dynast from the Devi Lal clan



J&K People's Conference (JKPC), J&K: **Sajjad Lone** inherited the mantle from father and party founder, Abdul Ghani Lone

SAFFRON DYNASTIES

Dynasty, by any reckoning, is antithetical to real democracy. But part of the dilemma is the genuine question of political legacy, and popular attachment to a titular face representing it. The BJP is not immune to this phenomenon, so there is the question of second-generation saffron dynasts. Earlier this year, the BJP denied a ticket to Utpal Parrikar, son of the late chief minister Manohar Parrikar, from Panaji, citing the 'no dynasty' rule. Panaji had been represented by Parrikar Senior for 25 years before his death in 2019. But then the party fielded Atanasio Monserrate from the seat, even though his wife Jennifer Monserrate, a cabinet minister in the Pramod Sawant government, was contesting from neighbouring Taleigao. Similarly, there's health minister Vishwajit Rane and his wife Deviya Rane, the MLA from Poriem. Vishwajit's father is six-term CM Pratapsingh Rane. So is the 'no dynasty' rule to be used selectively? (See *Family Rules Apply.*)

In neighbouring Maharashtra,